

Venue

Take this on the tour. Ask the person who will be there on the day, not the salesperson.

Candidate _____
Date _____

Bold questions are mine. The rest are the standard ones, and they still matter.

How far is the reception from the ceremony?

Too far and guests get lost, or skip it. Keep it close.

What are your time restrictions, and which slots are open on our date?

Most venues run more than one event a day. Their schedule becomes yours.

When can our providers get in to set up?

Ninety minutes to two hours is normal. A half hour because another event runs before ours is the trap, and it makes your team look late.

How late can the music run? Is there a noise rule near 10:00 PM, and when does your staff start breaking the room down?

I have watched a room get broken down while guests were still dancing. It looks tacky.

How far is this from where most of our guests live?

Past a 30-minute drive, people leave early. Close by, they stay.

How many people fit comfortably in one room?

No overflow room. I always advise against it; the people in it feel left out.

Is there parking for every guest, or do we need a valet?

Every single one, no excuses. Attending should never be a burden.

Is there enough power for the entertainment, and where is it?

Parks and many outdoor spots have none. Know it now, not on the day.

What is the bad-weather plan, who calls it, and by when?

Get the room, the person, and the hour. All three.

Is the dance floor in the middle of the room? If not, can it be?

A floor at the far end, around a corner, or in another room keeps people in their seats.

How many events run here at the same time as ours?

Four ceremonies at once confuses guests and dampens yours.

What is included: tables, chairs, linens, staff, the bar?

Which room is the rain plan, and is it held for us?

Is there a required or preferred vendor list, and what is the rule?

What is the out time, for guests and for our providers?

What insurance or licenses do you require of our providers?

Fit ○○○○ Answers ○○○○ Gut ○○○○ Decided ☐

Photographer and videographer

One take. Ask about time first, then about the team.

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How much time do you need for photos after the ceremony?

I plan on 45 minutes to an hour. Longer, and the guests are waiting and the food is sitting.

How long will sunset or moonrise photos take, and when?

The two of you gone too long reads as an invitation to leave.

When does your coverage end, and what does it cost to stay for the last hour?

Write their figure here. The last hour is where the fun photos are, and the photographer is usually gone.

Will you coordinate with the entertainment on the dance floor moments?

Nothing important should happen without you ready, and nothing should be rushed so you can leave.

How bright is your lighting, and where does it go?

A big light on a camera walking the dance floor clears the floor.

How fast do you answer email?

The pros answer promptly. You will find out during this process.

Fit ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ Answers ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ Gut ☐ ☐ ☐ ☐ Decided ☐

Can we see a full wedding, start to finish, not a highlight reel?

How many shooters on the day? Is a second shooter an add-on?

When do we get the photos and the film, and how?

How do you plan the family groupings, and who gathers people?

Who shows up if you cannot?

How are the files backed up on the day and after?

DJ, MC, or band

Experience is the name of the game. These questions find out who has it.

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How do you decide what to play, and how much say do we have?

I let people choose their songs, and I ask for autonomy. A list with no judgment behind it is a playlist, not entertainment.

What will you do to make this ours?

If the ideas do not come easily, look elsewhere.

What is your break policy, and what plays during a break?

A packed floor and a sudden fifteen-minute break. Think it has not happened?

Who is the MC, and can we hear them speak?

A good singer is not automatically a good announcer. Ask for a sample.

How do you plan the pace with us?

Someone who waits to be told the pace on the day is not running the room. To me, that is nuts.

Will you visit the venue before the day?

Room layout, extra speakers, the loading door. Not something to discover on the day.

What have you changed about your work in the last few years?

If they cannot answer, they stopped running.

Who exactly shows up on the day, and what if they cannot?

What backup equipment comes with you?

What power do you need, and where?

How long is setup, and when do you arrive?

Do you handle ceremony sound, with a mic for the officiant and readers?

How many mics for the toasts, and are they wireless?

What are the overtime terms? Write them down.

Are you insured, and can the venue see the certificate?

For a band: how will you play our special songs, what is your range, and what do you need to eat?

Fit ○○○○ Answers ○○○○ Gut ○○○○ Decided ☐

Venue accessibility walkthrough

For the site visit. Walk it the way a guest with a cane, a chair, or a hearing aid will, and check each box.

Candidate _____
Date _____

☐ Surfaces and steps from the parking to the ceremony

☐ Surfaces and steps from the ceremony to the restrooms

☐ Surfaces and steps from the restrooms to the dance floor

☐ Ramps, and how steep they are

☐ Sightlines from the back rows, and from a seated guest

☐ Seating near the aisle, and seating away from the speakers

☐ A quiet room, and where it is

☐ The volume the room will run at (ask, then listen during an event if you can)

☐ Lighting on the paths after dark

☐ Restrooms: an accessible stall, and the distance from the room

☐ Where a guest who cannot stand long can sit during the ceremony and the cocktail hour

☐ Whether a wheelchair or a walker can reach the dance floor and the head table

SEATING NOTES

Who needs the aisle, who needs to be away from the speakers, who needs a chair during the ceremony. This flows to the Team Sheet and the table plan.

Fit ○○○○ Answers ○○○○ Gut ○○○○ Decided ☐